Last Man Standing: Game Design Spec v2

Merged from the original spec and the team meeting. Items marked **OPEN** still need a team decision.

Game overview

A single-player, side-view 2D stealth/action platformer built in **Godot with GDScript**. Nero (working name, see OPEN), a former Keeper imprisoned for treason, escapes a dark prison tower floor by floor. As he descends he uncovers persecution, experimentation and a spreading sickness, while his brother repeatedly tries to stop him.

On each floor Nero plants a sigil. In the ending these are revealed as demolition charges. After fatally wounding his brother and escaping into the woods, he detonates them and the tower falls.

- **Target:** Desktop, 15 to 25 minutes
- **Structure:** Five short, handcrafted, vertically structured tower levels
- **Characters:** Nero (playable) and his brother (major speaking role)
- **Engine:** Godot, GDScript, placeholder graphics first
- **Assets:** Free existing assets only (Kenney All in 1 plus the team's shared free asset folder). No AI-generated visuals.

Creative pillars

1. **Descent reveals complicity.** Each floor exposes more of the institution's crimes and Nero's part in them.
2. **The brother is a person before he is a boss.** He opposes Nero without being a straightforward villain.
3. **Evidence supports competing interpretations.** The sickness is real and dangerous; the Keepers' response is cruel.
4. **Your choices color the story, not the ending.** Stealth and casualties change dialogue and cutscenes; the ending's events stay fixed.
5. **A small, complete experience.** Reusable enemies, compact levels, short dialogue.

Narrative rules

Nero's history is revealed gradually through dialogue and environment, no amnesia needed. He was imprisoned after opposing the Keepers' treatment of the symptomatic. The brother stays loyal to the order and has participated in or defended its abuses. Their relationship is revealed before the final level, and the ending leaves the morality of Nero's choice unresolved.

New from the meeting: a casualty counter tracks guards killed. Higher totals change the brother's lines and, at the top tier, reveal that Nero, not only the sickness, caused many deaths.

Controls

- **WASD:** move, climb ladders
- **Space:** jump
- **C:** dodge
- **1:** shank (melee)
- **2:** cloak (hides Nero in shadows)

- **3:** C4 (breaches locks and doors, exposes position)
- **Interact:** keys, switches, sigil anchors
- Guns: dropped by guards only (OPEN), firing exposes position

Core gameplay loop

Explore a floor, evade or fight Keepers, find one story beat, plant the floor's sigil at a fixed anchor, descend. Each level reuses earlier components and adds a small number of new elements: ladders, switches, obstacles, shadow zones, patrols.

Level progression

See the **Level progression** table on the board. Level 1 opens in Nero's cell with three escape routes: C4 on the lock, a key taken from a collapsed guard, or shanking the guard for the key.

The final encounter

Unchanged from v1. The brother blocks the exit and offers one last chance to rebuild the order. Two readable attacks, clear vulnerability windows, then a scripted exchange. Dying, he expresses affection and conviction, and his warning refers to evidence seen earlier. Nero leaves him, reaches the woods, the sigils fire in sequence and the tower collapses. Fade to black, no epilogue.

Branching (limited)

Branching only changes dialogue and cutscene variants. Inputs are stealth choices (detected or not) and the casualty count. Thresholds are OPEN; working proposal: Ghost (0), Bloodied (1 to 5), Butcher (6 or more).

Art direction

Low-res pixel art, side view. Palette: dark gray, blue, navy, rust, with mystical accents and moss and vine details where feasible. Characters use simple animations of about four frames or fewer. Distinguish the brothers by silhouette, color and equipment. Show symptoms with tints, overlays or particles.

Cutscenes

Short cutscenes of 10 to 15 seconds play between the five levels, with variants based on player choices. Plus an opening (imprisonment) and the ending (forest and tower collapse). Visuals come from the same free assets; AI may help with timing and structure only. Subtitles and skip are required, and skipping applies the same progression as watching.

Implementation requirements

Reusable scenes: player, guard, shadow/cover zone, switch, security control, sigil anchor, C4 breach point, ladder, level exit, boss, cutscene player. Fran sets up the level tree.

Track: current floor, sigils placed, casualty count, detection state, narrative milestones, boss outcome, ending completion. Restarting a floor restores its entry state, including its casualties. Sigils cannot be duplicated, cutscenes cannot trigger twice or leave input disabled.

Team

- **Fran:** coding lead, core mechanics, level tree, progression
- **Julia:** art and level design, asset selection, Nero and brother designs and animations, visual level implementation

Scope and completion criteria

The first complete build includes five floors with working objectives, one reusable guard and the brother boss, all core controls, five sigil placements, the casualty counter with dialogue variants, cutscenes between levels, and pause, subtitles, skip and a full exported playthrough. Cut first: gun pickups, extra enemy types, elaborate puzzles, optional rooms, cutscene variants.

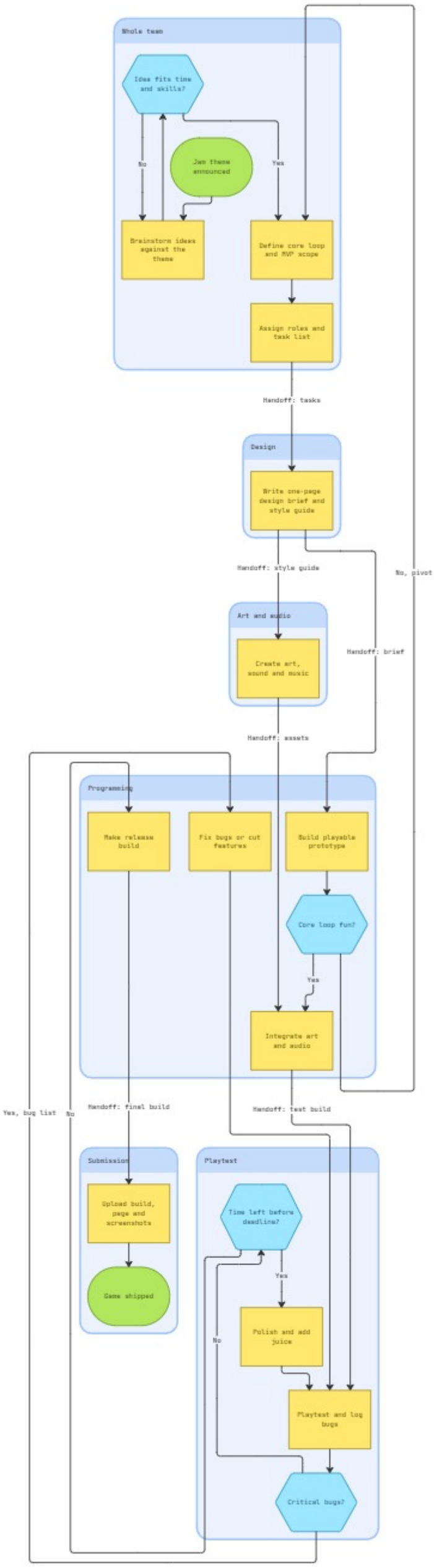
Open decisions

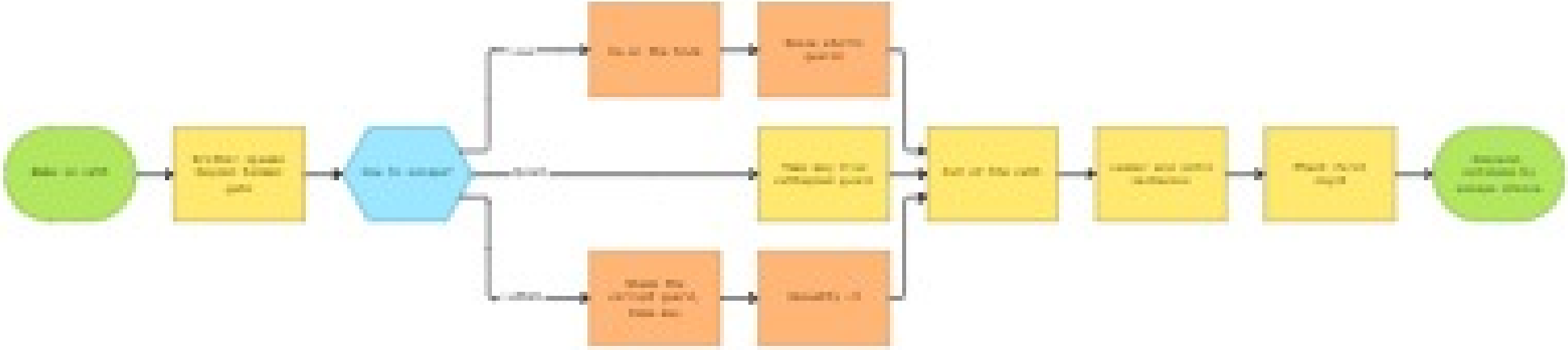
- Protagonist name: Nero or Miro?
- Godot and GDScript confirmed?
- Guns: dropped only, or core inventory?
- Are the sigils the same thing as the C4, or separate?
- Casualty thresholds and number of cutscene variants
- Higgsfield cinematics in v1 conflict with the no-AI-visuals decision. Drop them?
- From v1: the exact act of treason, what the sickness does, who is in the tower at the end, the evidence behind the brother's warning, what powers the sigils, and whether the seven-day window still applies

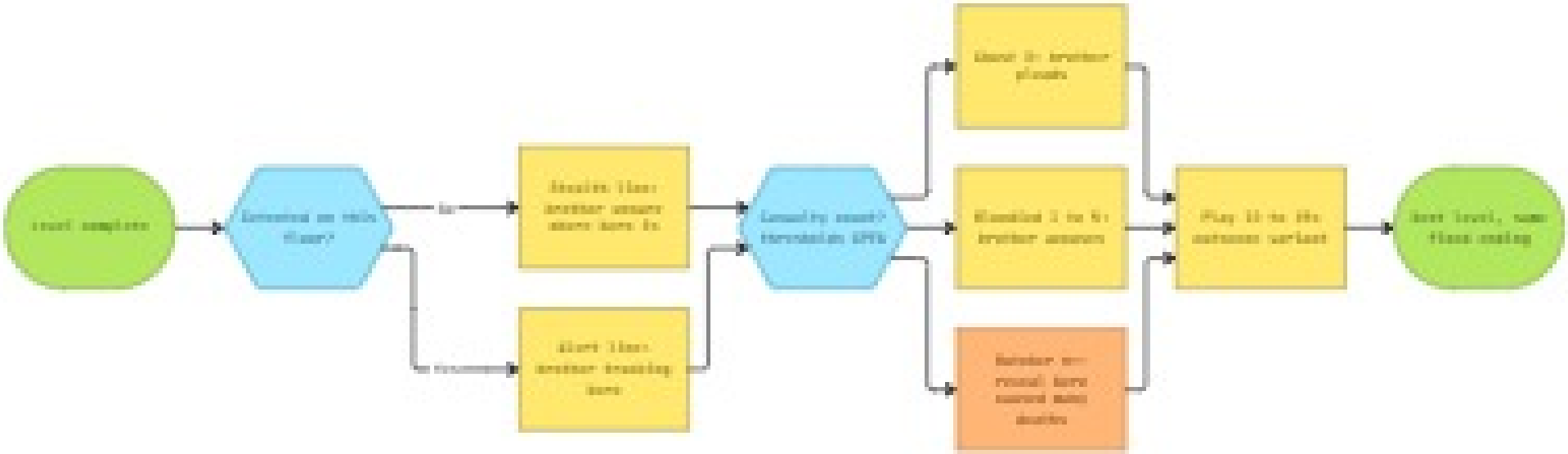
Level 1: The Prisoner

Drag the pieces into place to rebuild the lost sketch. Floors stack bottom to top.




Whole team
Idea fits time and skills?
No
Yes
Jam theme announced
Brainstorm ideas against the theme
Define core loop and MVP scope
Assign roles and task list
Handoff: tasks
Design
Write one-page design brief and style guide
Handoff: style guide
No, pivot
Art and audio
Create art, sound and music
Handoff: brief
Handoff: assets
Programming
Make release build
Fix bugs or cut features
Build playable prototype
Core loop fun?
Yes
Integrate art and audio
Yes, bug list
No
Handoff: final build
Handoff: test build
Submission
Upload build, page and screenshots
Game shipped
Playtest
Time left before deadline?
Yes
No
Polish and add juice
Playtest and log bugs
Critical bugs?





New game

Opening cutscene: Imprisonment

Nero dies on any floor?

Yes

Restart floor from entry state

Level 1: The Prisoner

Wake in cell, brother speaks beyond gate

How to escape the cell?

Lethal

Shank guard, casualty +1

Quiet

Key from collapsed guard

Loud

C4 on lock, guards alerted

Ladder, plant sigil 1

Cutscene 1: variant by escape choice

Level 2: The Symptoms

Patrols, shadows, sick prisoners

Past the patrols how?

Combat

Shank guards, casualties +

Stealth

Cloak through shadows

Brother offers surrender, plant sigil 2

Cutscene 2: variant by detection and casualties

Level 3: The Order

Security checkpoint, former rank revealed

Get through the checkpoint how?

Lethal

Fight through, loot dropped gun

Loud

Breach with C4, alarm raised

Quiet

Disable controls quietly

Brothers confirmed, plant sigil 3

Cutscene 3: variant by casualties

Level 4: The Ward

Sealed experimental ward, evidence of both sides

Through the ward how?

Combat

Fight, casualties +

Stealth

Sneak past

Brother warns, plant sigil 4

Casualty tier?

0

Cutscene 4: Ghost, brother pleads

1 to 5

Cutscene 4: Bloodied, brother accuses

6 or more

Cutscene 4: Butcher, Nero's death toll revealed

Level 5: The Brother

Plant final sigil 5

Brother blocks exit, offers to rebuild the order

Brother defeated?

Yes

Dying words, vary by casualty tier

No / Refuses

Boss fight: two attacks, vulnerability windows

Escape to the woods, look back

Ending cutscene: sigils fire, tower collapses

Fade to black